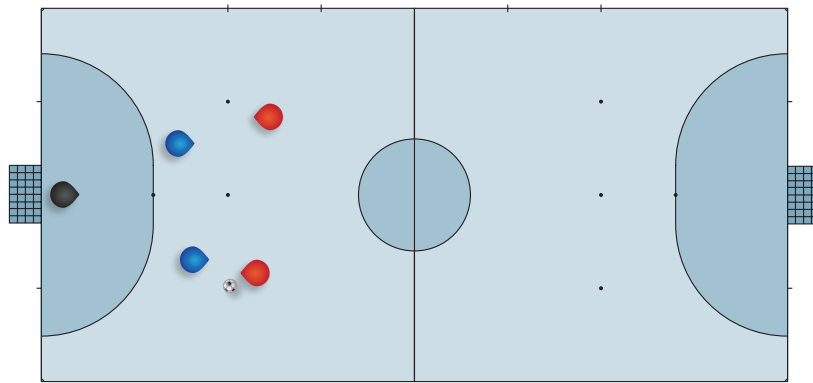


1.4.3.9 Marking

Does the opponent have the ball or not?

If the opponent has the ball, the defender moves into a position between the opponent, the ball and the goal. However, if the player from the other team does not have the ball, the defender must still be positioned between their opponent and the goal, inside a triangle formed by the position of the ball, the position of the attacking player and the middle of the goal. The defender must take up the most suitable position inside this triangle, depending on the game situation.



Positioning and marking.

Challenging an opponent who has the ball: position of the legs

When it comes to teaching beginners, the textbooks state that the defender must not challenge the player in possession with their legs in line with their shoulders (feet parallel) because they could easily lose their balance. Instead, the defender should challenge with one foot forward and the other slightly behind them. Which foot goes forward and which back depends on the tactical decision made by the defender.

The defender's strong and weak sides in relation to the position of their feet

By putting one foot ahead of another, a defender automatically creates a strong side and a weak side. The strong side is where they can move more easily (side corresponding to the back foot) whereas the other foot is referred to as the weak side (side corresponding to the front foot).

Tactical considerations for a defender in one-on-one situations: drawing a player into a particular move

The defender can force the attacking player to move in the direction they want them to (where the forward is not as dangerous, e.g. out wide, a long way from the goal) and draw the player towards the defender's own strong side.

Tactical considerations for a defender in a one-on-one situation: various solutions

Is the opponent one-footed (i.e. do they overwhelmingly use just their right or left foot)? If so, they should be pushed onto their weaker foot.

Otherwise, it might be best for them to be ushered inside because there are more defenders in the central part of the court, or because the defender knows they are dangerous when shooting towards the back post and wants to prevent a dangerous situation developing in the next phase of play.

Problems involved in showing an opponent one side or the other

If the defender decides to show the attacking player one side or the other, they must make sure that the attacker actually goes where they want them to. To achieve this, the defender should ensure that the attacker is positioned no further forward than an imaginary line running between their (the defender's) legs.

What is the main aim of a defender in a one-on-one situation?

The answer may seem obvious in that the primary objective is to avoid being beaten. Therefore, in general, when starting to defend, the defender must go with the attacker who has the ball. Furthermore, they must pretend to go for the ball (tackle) to unsettle the forward and make them uncertain about how much time and room they actually have.

Challenging an opponent (front-on) as they are about to receive the ball

It is important to close down the forward who is about to receive the ball at the right time (while the ball is travelling between the passer and the player receiving it). Moreover, the defender must make sure they stop and remain at a safe distance just before the attacking player receives the ball.

Defender marking an opponent who has the ball with their back to goal

The defender must learn to avoid fouling while preventing their opponent from turning to face the goal. Furthermore, they must not let the forward use the defender's own body as a pivot point, enabling them to turn and beat them.

Marking an opponent who does not have the ball

The defender should generally be positioned between their opponent and the goal they are defending, while keeping an eye on both the opponent and the ball. The defender will be in difficulty if they lose track of the player and ball (i.e. if the forward has moved behind the defender).

Taking into account the opponent's characteristics and position when marking

The safety margin varies depending on the forward's speed, build, technical ability, etc.

The further the forward is from the ball and the goal they are attacking, the looser the marking (more covering, less marking).

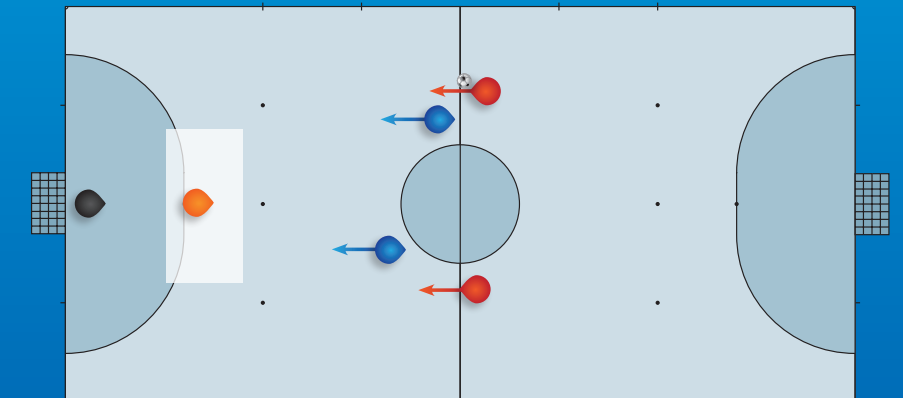
The closer the forward is to the ball and the goal they are attacking, the tighter the marking (less covering, more marking).

Marking or covering?

The main dilemma faced by defenders is deciding to what extent they should mark their opponent and to what extent they should just cover them. They need to consider the position of the opponent and the time and room available to the player with the ball (is the passing angle 'open' or 'closed'?).

Drill for defensive marking and covering

19



DRILL DESCRIPTION

Playing in half a court, the two players in possession must pass the ball to their team-mate standing in a 6x3m zone marked out in front of the goal close to the edge of the penalty area. When this team-mate receives

the ball, they take a shot at goal. The two defenders attempt to prevent this using a 'marking and covering' action. Only the player who receives the ball and shoots can enter the marked-out zone.

